

Website presenting our groups path: <https://kas-project.vercel.app>
itch.io: <https://kirazaz.itch.io/kas>

Postmortem - KAS (Vertical Slice)

RGP204: Rapid Game Prototype - Assessment 3

Kira Zakirov

Introduction

KAS is a gothic 3D platformer that our three-person team developed across three assessments. The entire concept of the game was Alexander's: the idea, the gothic world and the core design are all to his credit; he also handled the sound and several of the models. Sarah was responsible for the 3D art, animation and level design, but her role went well beyond that - she patiently supported the whole team, wrote step-by-step instructions for Alexander and got on calls to explain clearly how things should be done. I was responsible for the C# programming, the WebGL build, the showcase website and the final debugging. What follows is an honest evaluation of both the vertical slice and the process of making it.

Did we achieve the goals of the project?

On the whole, yes. We achieved the goals we set, although we had to trim the original plan because of time constraints. The vertical slice brings together at least two mechanics from our previous prototypes - the double jump, glide and i-frames from the first assessment, and the crafting, inventory and rune-puzzle systems from the second - combined into a single polished level. The game launches and is playable directly in the browser (WebGL on itch.io and on our website), with UI, sound and "juice" effects, and the level ends with a finale in the cave that only opens once the player has crafted the required items. In short, the key goals were met - simply at a more modest scope than we first envisaged.

Were the project's expectations realistic?

Not from the very start. The original plan was noticeably broader than what could realistically be built in the time available with only three people. The turning point was discussing and reviewing it together: we honestly assessed what we could manage and deliberately narrowed the scope - and only then did the goal become realistic and achievable. That decision proved to be the right one. The brief stresses the importance of sensible scoping, and our experience confirmed it: it is better to do less but finish it well than to try to cover everything and end up with a rushed result.

What went right? What went wrong?

The greatest strength was building on work we had already done: the mechanics and assets from the first two assessments gave us a solid foundation, so the slice was assembled from proven parts rather than reinvented. Teamwork was another strength. The division of tasks by area of responsibility did not fall into place immediately, but at

some point, each of the three of us clearly understood our own area - and by the end the team was working noticeably more smoothly.

We communicated mostly through our shared group chat, with a call when needed, and throughout the project everyone remained polite and professional, supporting one another where things were difficult.

The weaker points were mainly technical and organisational. Some bugs only appeared in the built game rather than in the editor: the glide feathers disappeared in the WebGL build because URP strips the shader they used; the lyre HUD icon turned magenta because the code reached for an already-stripped shader; and the turret model broke due to incorrect material assignment. Finding and fixing such things took time. Polishing slipped toward the end, and some of the work was done in a rush against the deadline. Organisationally, there was a lack of clarity at the very start - the areas of responsibility only took shape later.

What can we learn for next time?

The main lesson is that we should have written down the areas of responsibility from the very start and agreed who owns what, so that everything was clear from day one rather than being worked out as we went.

The second is to test the game in the build as early as possible, not only in the editor: the “works in the editor, not in the build” gap is a classic URP/WebGL trap, and testing builds sooner would have saved hours.

The third is to manage scope more firmly during planning; we got there in the end, but not right away.

Conclusion

KAS achieved its key goals: it is a coherent, playable and polished vertical slice that grew out of our prototypes. The most valuable lessons concern the process rather than the game itself - assign responsibilities in writing and up front, test builds earlier, and manage scope with discipline. Despite the tight timeline and the final rush, the project was a valuable experience in team development that we will carry into future projects.